The Frontiersman: George E. Taylor and the Transnational Making of the Cold War Intellectual, 1905-1959

A Thesis

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The contours of academic life ultimately conform
in very large measure with the realities of power.
— George E. Taylor, 1959

Introduction

Beginning in the mid-twentieth century, the United States underwent a profound, world-historical transformation: the rise of Cold War liberalism reshaped American liberal traditions under the conditions of an emerging national security state, drove the global expansion of U.S. power and its demand for area-studies expertise; and remade universities into state-funded centers of knowledge production, professionalized intellectual labor, and public consciousness building.[1]

In examining the relationship between Cold War liberalism and its intellectual proponents, George E. Taylor served as an illuminative figure. Taylor played a definitive role in the making of China study by the end of Second World War and throughout the first decade of the Cold War—a decade of epistemological formation, in which the what, how, why, and for whom of knowledge about China were in incubation and contestation. It was also a decade of intense debate over intellectual frameworks, shaped by the victory of Mao Zedong's Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and the establishment of the People's Republic of China (PRC), and the retreat of Chiang Kai-shek's Kuomintang (KMT)–led Republic of China (ROC) to Taiwan and

[1] For literature on the Cold War military–intellectual complex, the formation of intellectual labor within Cold War universities and think tanks, and the ideology of Cold War liberalism, see Daniel Bessner *Democracy in Exile: Hans Speier and the Rise of the Defense Intellectual*; Christopher Simpson, ed., *Universities and Empire: Money and Politics in the Social Sciences during the Cold War*; Rebecca S. Lowen, *Creating the Cold War University: The Transformation of Stanford*; Joy Rohde, *Armed with Expertise: The Militarization of American Social Research during the Cold War*; and Daniel Bessner and Michael Brenes, eds., *Cold War Liberalism: Power in a Time of Emergency*.

its influence campaign, the "China Lobby," in the United States. The interplay of Cold War (ill-)liberalism across public life and academic agendas presented Taylor and his contemporaries an array of imminent questions: the Chinese Communists' relationship to China's imperial past; the positions of the PRC and ROC in an America-led world; and means of obtaining research materials on the contested waters of the Asia-Pacific.[2]

The making of Taylor as a Cold War intellectual entailed the particularity of mid-twentieth-century United States in the world: his British upbringing, his transnational intellectual formation and his participation in America's global order building—all resembled and emendated the current scholarship regarding the multifaceted origins of the American Century—immigration and exile, the Cold War universities and the rise of the military-intellectual complex; a history concerns not only the world we live in as an aftermath of the Cold War project, but also reveals knowledge-making as inseparable from political power, with the traditions of dead generations weighing like a nightmare on the living.[3]

In the formative decades from the 1920s to the 1940s, George E. Taylor's transformation from a Marxian historian of nineteenth-century China into a KMT anti-Communist defense intellectual; his exploration of modernization theory in defense of Chiang Kai-shek's war against the CCP; and his involvement in the Office of War Information for value and propaganda studies

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[2] For literature on the China Lobby, see Robert E. Herzstein, *Henry Luce, Time, and the American Crusade in Asia*; Ross Y. Koen, *The China Lobby in American Politics*; and Joyce Mao, *Asia First: China and the Making of Modern American Conservatism*.

[3] For literature on the Weimar experience in the making of the first generation of Cold War intellectuals, see Udi Greenberg, *The Weimar Century: German Émigrés and the Ideological Foundations of the Cold War*; and Bessner, *Democracy in Exile*. For debate on the scope of the Cold War liberal if it could be applied to normative more conservative intellectuals yet them could be perceived as part of a liberal forward-pastured American global project see
For Marx's famous quote, see Karl Marx, *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, chap. 1, trans. Saul K. Padover, 1.

revealed an unique transnational origin of the Cold War intellectual. To trace Taylor's intellectual lineage, I argue that his Cold War institution-building at the University of Washington and his work in psychological and communications warfare in the Asia-Pacific grew directly out of his prewar experience in semi-colonial Asia. It served as a powerful example of the emergence of a global America whose frontiers stretched across continents and oceans, and whose liberal intellectual project aimed to encompass all civilizations—a project of dominance that predated the formal beginning of the Cold War.

The Early Life of Taylor

George Edward Taylor was born on December 13, 1905, in Coventry, England, child of Thomas Taylor, a railway goods checker, and Sarah Ann Chapman, a dressmaker. Although born into a working class family, Taylor, as a first-generation student, attended the Bablake School, a tuition-paying public school.[4] In 1924, he entered the University of Birmingham on a scholarship and continued into his master's program when the funds were sufficient.[5] Upon finishing his M.A. thesis, "The Tudor Privy Council: A Study in Administration," under the supervision of Charles Raymond Beazley, Taylor took upon a Commonwealth Fund Fellowship to Johns Hopkins University and Harvard University in 1928.[6]

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[4] George E. Taylor, *George E. Taylor: Memoir, 1950–1946*, ed. Claire E. Taylor, Version 1.3 (March 2006), self-published, vii, 7.

[5] Taylor, *Memoir*, 31, 33.

[6] Taylor, *Memoir*, 38; "University of Washington BIOGRAPHY," 1975, Box 1, Folder 3, Accession 1695-007, *George Edward Taylor Papers, 1932–1999*, University of Washington Libraries Special Collections, Seattle, 2; "Biographical Statement George E. Taylor," 1944, Box 1, Folder 1, *Taylor Papers*, 1.

Great Britain, along with its intellectual culture, left an early imprint on his life. Taylor came to learn a British imperial history and geography shaped by nineteenth-century "stages of development" theory that favored the industrial modern West as the latest and inevitable path of human societies.[7] He was exposed to notable thinkers including Karl Marx, Bernard Shaw, G. K. Chesterton, Philip Noel-Baker, and Goldsworthy Lowes Dickinson—the young Taylor gravitated toward their skepticism of the European empires in the shadow of World War I's destruction.[8]

The two scholars who influenced Taylor the most were R. H. Tawney and E. D. Morel. Tawney, a Christian socialist, pioneered an economic approach to Chinese history in his 1932 *Land and Labour in China*. Taylor developed a personal intellectual camaraderie with him and later attributed Tawney's *The Acquisitive Society* and *Equality* to have the greatest impact on him. While Morel's exposure of Belgian slavery and imperialism in the Congo inspired Taylor to go to the United States, Taylor wrote, "[I] wanted to get Americans out of the Philippines as well as British out of their Empire."[9] Taylor, like many intellectually ambitious young Englishmen of modest background, sought both a way of knowing beyond imperialism and a world beyond the waning British Empire.

Taylor's arrival in the United States marked a personal as well as intellectual turning point. In early 1929, his future wife, Roberta White, introduced him to a lecture by Arthur W. Hummel, director of the Orientalia Division of the Library of Congress and a prominent missionary-Sinologist. Christian missionary activity in China also shaped White's intellectual and personal background: born in China, White was the daughter of Francis and Ivy White, who

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[7] Taylor, *Memoir*, 39.

[8] Taylor, *Memoir*, 42, 44-45.

[9] Taylor, *Memoir*, 42, 44-45.

served as missionaries at Shanghai Baptist University.[10] Soon, Hummel introduced Taylor to the Chinese language resources at Harvard University, and subsequently, to the opportunity to apply for the inaugural Harvard-Yenching Fellowship of 1930.

What America left on Taylor was not only the sheer scale of its landmass but also a new outlook of the world, of continental blocks and oceans that has constructed a concert of geopolitical order. In America, he read Alfred Mahan's *The Influence of Sea Power upon History*; Taylor recalled this education as enlightening: "there was much more to the world than the Empire and Europe. Latin America came to life, as did China. It began to dawn on me that the world was round."[11] Geopolitics, as a rational game of planning conducted from the center, from the North American continent outward to the peripheries of strategic highlands and long buffer zones, renewed Taylor's British imperial education. It preserved its emphasis on sea power, yet also introduced a new awareness of land and political force beyond the direct colonial control of the imperial core, an aspect largely omitted by British thought.

His geopolitical thinking has persisted throughout the decade: in an 1940 writing to address the Molotov-Ribbentrop pact and its impact to America's position in Asia-Pacific, Taylor interpreted the Eurasia continent as connected by great powers on the two ends—the land power the Soviet Union and the hybrid maritime-and-land power of Imperial Japan; if America wanted to "held the key," words of choice, to the gridlock, it should pursue a close relationship with China and pay special attention to the inner Asia heartland.[12] Would have been brewing for the

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[10] Taylor, *Memoir*, 51, 117-119

[11] Taylor, *Memoir*, 57.

[12] Taylor, "Current Theories of Power Politics in the Far East…" February 21, 1940, Box 2, *Taylor Paper*, 10.

coming decade, at the time Taylor left America for China, he carried the exuberance of a rising nation that viewed world affairs as a single chessboard.

Taylor's Atlantic and Pacific Crossing: Marx at Yenching

Crossing the Atlantic en route to England and continuing via the Trans-Siberian Railway, Taylor arrived in Peking in September 1930. Rather than settling into the life of an academic hermit, his first year in China was filled with Lawrence-of-Arabia-esque adventures. Taylor toured attractions in Peking and Tientsin, reveled with fellow expatriates and traveled to Inner Mongolia to take part in disaster relief and labor organization efforts.[13]

At Yenching University, Taylor continued his interest in land and politics, drawing on the intellectual lineage of R. H. Tawney while working under the guidance of William Hung 洪業, whom he had first met as a visiting scholar at Harvard. His research benefited from the KMT's opening of the imperial archives following its consolidation of national power after the Northern Expedition of 1927. Within this context, Taylor turned to the Taiping Rebellion—a nineteenth-century Christian uprising and one of the major events in China's political transformation across the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.[14]

In Taylor's 1933 Yenching thesis *Taiping Rebellion: Its Economic Background and Social Theory*, Taylor approached this subject via the lens of political economy—the politics of land and wealth redistribution. The idiosyncratic relationship between a peasant uprising, one of the most recurring elements of Chinese history and its Christian veneer, revealed the greater

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[13] Taylor, *Memoir*, 81–90, 97–102; see also "Trek to a Monastery in the Western Hills," Box 2, *Taylor Papers*.

[14] Taylor, *Memoir*, 101-102, "Jackson School Oral History Project" transcript, interview by Sharon Boswell, 1996, 40, Box 10, Folders 22–26, *Taylor Papers.*

intellectual framing of Taylor—that the Taiping movement was "a revolution born of the fact that economic change had outrun the growth of social theory," that mid-and late nineteenth century China was undergoing a civilizational disintegration, a revolution that against its tradition.[15]

The making of the Taiping movement was a perfect storm of social, fiscal, and economic pressures. Over less than two centuries, China's population roughly tripled, while cultivated land increased by only about thirty-five percent. The imbalance pushed much of the peasantry into deepening desperation. At the same time, the High Qing's territorial expansion drained imperial wealth, while the land-poll taxation system constrained the growth of state revenue. Meanwhile, domestic commerce and trade with the West assumed an increasingly important role in the economy, even as the fiscal structure of the empire failed to adjust.[16] The imperial court's failure to manage the economy, and its subsequent social upheaval, were worsened by the ethnic undercurrent of the Manchu ruling house's conflict with the majority of Han Chinese and the ongoing conquest and inquisition of the frontiers—with sporadic rebellions on all corners of empire boiled into the cataclysm of the Taiping movement.[17]

Taylor saw the Taiping movement as a breaking point when the political thesis of the old neither explained the current circumstance nor provided a prescription for the future. To challenge the "the very nature and existence of Chinese civilisation," in which Taylor as not "adaptable to changing economic conditions" and as fundamentally lacking "equality of opportunity," the Christianity of the West "breathed into this agrarian movement the hopes and

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[15] George Edward Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion: Its Economic Background and Social Theory," Chinese Social and Political Science Review 16, no. 4 (1932): 545–614, HeinOnline, 548.

[16] Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 572.

[17] Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 573-579.

ideals" that demanded, "the brotherhood of man…and the theory of a redistribution of wealth according to need."[18] Taylor referred to the Taiping idealism as Christian communism.[19]

Taylor's analysis therefore drew a parallel between the Chinese Communists of the 1930s and his historical subject, while also framing the human–land disparity as a legitimate cause for this long process of the rise of an un-Chinese ideology, as a demonstration of the "agrarian problem." Nevertheless, Taylor concluded the movement altogether negatively: the peasant's "mind had not been prepared for a redistribution of wealth," and he saw the body politic as not readily constituting a new citizenry—"many were ready for dynastic change, but few were ready for revolution." The trajectory of the new Heavenly Kingdom followed many of the old: "[b]ad leadership, internal dissensions, lack of supplies, weakening of morale," and its coming demise became obvious.[20]

> A revolution can never be consistent: the strain on human nature is too great; ideas at first but vaguely understood become more sharply defined, or change so much as to be unrecognisable. This happened to the Taiping as to all revolutions. The men who had taken from the rich to relieve the poor, remained as a scourge to both. Of the leaders who penned edicts on love and brotherhood some were murdered in their palaces, and one left in anger and despair to set up an independent kingdom in another province. Those who sought to spread a new religion succeeded in establishing a new dynasty...whose who had risen with the hope of a new social order came to be guilty of punishments, of a nepotism,

[18] The Taiping program called for land to be classified into nine grades, allotted according to household size, and balanced through "a fair division of good and bad land"; it further imagined a condition in which "all shall eat food" and "in all things shall there be equality." See Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 595.

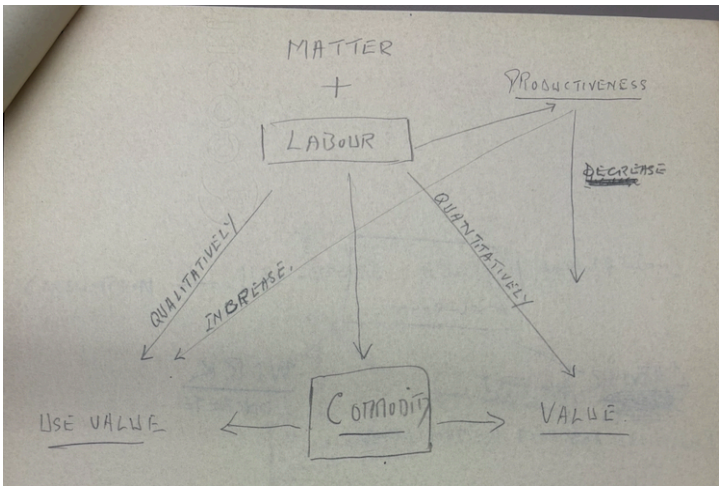
[19] Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 598

[20] Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 610.

> censorship and corruption, which in spite of some real achievements, at the time of their suppression left little to choose between them and the established dynasty.[21]

In Taylor's final remark, he stressed an ontological tragedy of revolution, in a generalized view that rejected utopian idealism and asserted an inevitability of new oppression arising from fallible human nature.

Taylor's pessimism toward revolution also revealed his ambiguous historiography: while writing his thesis, Taylor turned to Karl Marx's 1850s journalism for the *New York Daily Tribune* as a primary source on how the Taiping Rebellion appeared within a wider nineteenth-century world, situating it against the backdrop of the Anglo-Russian Great Game and the American Civil War. In Taylor's research file, notable articles included "Socialism in China," "Revolution in China and in Europe," and "Persia–China."[22] In Taylor's sketch, his exploration of the relationship between labor and value further cemented the Marxist tint of his theory building, as he diagrammed labor not simply as productive activity but as the mediating force through which matter became commodity, use value, and value.[23]



[21] Taylor, "The Taiping Rebellion," 610-611.

[22] "Taiping Rebellion Files," Box 7, Folders 24, *Taylor Papers*.

[23] "Taiping Rebellion Files," Box 7, Folders 25-26, *Taylor Papers*.

(Photograph by Francis Albert Shen, University of Washington Libraries Special Collections, Seattle)

A Marxian lens without Marxist proscription for revolution, Taylor situated his intellectual project within a materialist view of nineteenth-century China's long decline: trade, capital, and technology severed a mutually reinforcing force with the birth of new political ideology: the amalgamation of Chinese land ownership dialectically engendered the landless to break out of the imperial and Confucian paradigm and to demand a new social revolution. However, Taylor also held a tragic view of history, in which the average citizen of a society like China was destined for violence and tyranny after the initial rupture of mass resistance.

Decline, rupture, and failure were Taylor's main narrative—his intellectual pursuit did not pause at the fall of the Heavenly Kingdom, but extended to a general theory of the transformation of China. From 1933 to 1937, Taylor traveled between China and England while working on his unfinished book project, titled *A Study of the Decay of the Ch'ing Dynasty and the Background of Modern Problems from the Economic and Social Point of View*. In Taylor's framework, the West functioned less as an external destroyer than as a catalytic force that accelerated contradictions already embedded within Qing society: the familiar late-dynastic failures of imperial governance in taxation, land tenure, and labor relations, interacted with the growth of commercial wealth and foreign trade, in ways that compounded, rather than relieved rural immiseration. The destabilization of the old scholar-elite governance ignited the long resentment against the architecture of Manchu rule—dual administration, ethnic balancing, and increasing repression to the point of systemic breakdown.[24]

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[24] "Taiping Rebellion Files," Box 7, Folders 35, *Taylor Papers*.

By 1937 when Taylor finished his mandatory Commonwealth Fund Scholarship service to the British Empire at British Museum and returned to Yenching University to implement the British Tutor system in China, he had become a rising historian of China—his approach to China's shock and transformation belonged to school of thought named "impact-response," popularized by Ssu-yü Têng and John King Fairbank's 1954 *China's Response To The West: A Documentary Survey, 1839-1923*. Both Taylor and Fairbank attributed their intellectual inspiration to Tsiang Tingfu, an Confusian-literati-upbring American-trained historian, who taught at Tsinghua University and was an editor of *Chinese Social and Political Science Review* in the 1930s.[25]

Tsiang Tingfu's intellectual works ranged from Christianity in China to late-Qing diplomatic history—within the circle of scholars like C. K. Webster and R. H. Tawney, Tsiang's initial scholarship, took its touch from H. B. Morse's "blueprint" of the late Qing in the world, and he became the head of the History Department at Tsinghua by 1929. Tsiang resembled many Chinese intellectuals in the immediate aftermath of the 1911 Revolution: he saw the kaleidoscopes of Western thoughts, nationalism, socialism, communism, and fascism alike and observed politics in London and Moscow indifferently, both as contexts to which China and its long Confucianism had to react. Yet the old Confucian model was ineffective in a rising world of Darwinian national struggles, epitomized by the 1933 Japanese invasion of Manchuria. Survival became inextricably linked to progress and, in Tsiang's view, had to be materialized through Chiang Kai-shek's military might and its momentum for modernization.[26]

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[25] Taylor, *Memoir*, 131; "T.F. Tsiang and Modernization," John King Fairbank, *Chinabound: A Fifty Year Memoir* (New York: Harper & Row, 1982), 85-93; Taylor, "Fellowship Application," Box 3.

[26] Fairbank, "T. F. Tsiang and Modernization," in *Chinabound*, 85–93.

Taylor channeled Tsiang's dynamic view of China-West contact, similar to Tsiang, attempting to prescribe for China's progress. In the last chapter of his *A Study of the Decay* manuscript, Taylor divided war-wrenched China's governing entities into four types: "Western," "Semi-Western," "Modified Inter-dynastic," and "Communism,"corresponding respectively to Chiang Kai-shek's Nanjing government, the post–Sun Yat-sen KMT Left in Canton, the fragmented Beiyang warlord regimes in the provinces, and the Jiangxi Soviet Republic that Chiang was attempting to suppress. Paralleling Tsiang's gradual support for Chiang, Taylor recalibrated his original framework toward a more favorable interpretation of the KMT.[27]

2 ~~b.~~ Triumph of the Kuomintang: - *Establishment of [the] Government in Nanking*

Suppression of communism. ~~The Terror~~. *Civil War.*

Relation ~~Alliance~~ with foreign powers.

(italicized for handwriting)[28]

Whether in 1933 or by 1937, Taylor's approach was novel, widely remarked as the first of its kind in the field; what seemed poised to follow was a career of professional dedication and stability. However, amidst the Kwantung Army's onslaught after the Mukden incident, the war drums of the Marco Polo Bridge and the shadow of the Second World War, the direction of Taylor's career shifted markedly.

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[27] Taylor to L. Haden Guest, Esq., ca. 1936–1937, Box 3, *Taylor Papers*.

[28] Taylor, "Fellowship Application: Plan for Work, ca. 1936–1937," Box 3, *Taylor Papers.*

China in the Far East: KMT and Reconstruction

In February 20, 1935, Taylor wrote to Donald Goodchild of the American Council of Learned Societies for scholarship funding to travel over "the Taiping country from Kwangsi to the Yangtse, and over the province of Kiangsi where Communists held out for so long" for his another unfinished book project *A Study of Revolution in China*.[29] After he completed *The Taiping Rebellion* in late 1932, Taylor had spent two and a half years teaching at the Central Political Institute in Nanking, where he attempted to analyze the Taiping Rebellion's past to advise the KMT's "reconstruction" in reoccupied Kiangsi.[30] Unlike Yenching's open scholarship and idyllic campus scene for upper-middle-class Chinese students who wanted to receive an American education, the Central Political Institute was a party cadre school of the KMT amidst the First Chinese Civil War.

Taylor shifted his interest from compiling and annotating Qing era documents to political affairs, as the Civil War loomed large. KMT's efforts to suppress and eliminate the CPC were implemented through a war strategy named "encirclement," an effort to exterminate Communist forces around their "Soviet Republic bases" and to erect political resettlement that reinvariated pre-Communist modes of land, economic and political relationships.[31] In the summer of 1934, Taylor and his colleague Chow Shu-kai 周書楷 traveled to Kiangsi after the Fifth Encirclement

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[29] Taylor to Goodchild, February 20, 1935, Box 7, Folders 34, *Taylor Papers*.

[30] Taylor to Goodchild, February 20, 1935, Box 7, Folders 34, *Taylor Papers*; Taylor, *Memoir*, 123-129.

[31] Wilbur W. Hsu, *Survival Through Adaptation: The Chinese Red Army and the Extermination Campaigns, 1927–1936*(Fort Leavenworth, KS: Combat Studies Institute Press, 2012), 6.

Campaign had driven the Communists from their base areas, initiated the Long March: they canvassed the ruins of the town and collected propaganda posts.[32]

Beside Taylor's initial liberal arts teaching agenda, European Diplomatic History, Russian History and English, he started to train and advise KMT cadres who were interested in pursuing a career in diplomacy.[33] While his comparative studies between Taiping and the Communists drew great attention in Nanking, from Rotary Clubs to the KMT intellectual apparatus, Taylor offered an analysis similar to his *Taiping* thesis: both rebellions arose from real immiseration but failed to revolutionize as they recoiled against Chinese tradition and the grinding power of established governments.[34]

In 1935, Owen Lattimore, the newly appointed editor of *Pacific Affairs*, invited Taylor to contribute a paper on China's revolutions; having known Lattimore since his first Commonwealth Fund Fellowship year at Johns Hopkins, Taylor agreed. In September, *Pacific Affairs* published Taylor's paper "Reconstruction After Revolution: Kiangsi Province and the Chinese Nation." Marking a significant departure from his earlier Marxian framework, Taylor offered an uncritical account of the KMT's resettlement and reconstruction policies and praised the Party's efforts to organize and re-educate the peasantry with moral characters.

"A clean sweep made possible a clean start," Taylor mourned the ruins of Kiangsi by the Communists; he applauded Chiang Kai-shek as "[his] personality…[was the] most impressive

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[32] Taylor, *Memoir*, 12; I have not found documentation indicating how Taylor used these documents, under whose authority he worked, or in what capacity he was involved in the Encirclement Campaigns in his personal papers.

[33] Taylor to Goodchild, February 20, 1935, Box 7, Folders 34, *Taylor Papers*.

[34] "A Study in Chinese History," Box 3, Folder 8-10, *Taylor Papers*.

thing in Kiangsi." Chiang reconstructed Jiangxi on two planes—economy and culture. Taylor introduced the KMT's National Economic Council's provisional branch, funded by American loans; the Blue Shirts Society's Magistrates' Training School, a proto-fascist institution; and Chung Shan (Sun Yat-sen) People's Schools under the banner of the New Life Movement. In Taylor's account, Chiang Kai-shek implemented the pao-chia system, a peasant collective for communal labor and mutual surveillance enforced through collective punishment, and established Young Farmers' Moral Endeavor Societies that blended Confucian ethics with modern civic virtues.[35]

Taylor saw the Kiangsi experiment to be unique: both in anti-Communism tactics and general theory of governance. First, Taylor prescribed that KMT rightfully armed and funded "those classes of the population that have most to fear from Communism." The movement reclaimed land from the peasantry to wealthy landlords while mobilizing a tightly organized propaganda network that reached every sector of society, from children to the elderly. Second, Taylor briefly developed a set of methods for social governance: "[a]ction and energy on the one side, scientific experiment and planning on the other, [were] both essential in Kiangsi," he wrote, arguing that Kiangsi was a laboratory of renewed politics that broke away from the corruption and incompetence of thousands of years of dynastic politics[36]

Taylor nevertheless observed that the agrarian problem remained unresolved and neglected by officials, warning that so long as these conditions persisted, communism could not be eradicated. Yet he maintained hope that "good government is the answer to revolution,"

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[35] George E. Taylor "Reconstruction After Revolution: Kiangsi Province and the Chinese Nation," Pacific Affairs, Vol. 8, No. 3 (Sep., 1935), pp. 302-311.

[36] Taylor, "Reconstruction," 309.

believing that prosperity could raise the general standard of living to a level at which the poor, although still exploited, would no longer revolt.[37] The changing view of Taylor marked a fundamental shift in his beliefs—in a conflict whose cumulative casualties, by Taylor's own estimate, reached one million against the CCP, he had come to associate himself with the KMT.[38] Amidst the waning Marxian materialism, instead of land and wealth redistribution, Taylor opened up other possible avenues of social change, such as the building of a modern state and the application of "scientific methods," in which he referred to tying institutions with procedures, persuading the populace in a forward-looking organizational life.

Taylor's tenure at the Central Political Institute was cut short by Roberta's health and consideration of giving birth back in the United Kingdom; taking this opportunity, Taylor fulfilled his duty to serve one year for Great Britain in return to the initial two years stipulations of the Commonwealth Fund in the United States. In the summer of 1937, Taylor returned to Yenching, as the Second World War on the East Front had broken out on July 7th, 1937—the campus of Yenching, registered as an American institution, enjoyed exterritoriality from Japanese incursion, granting Taylor intellectual and physical freedom.[39] In 1938, Taylor wrote to his family that "the problem of China [against Japanese aggression] is insoluble" unless "she unites and adopts Western forms of organization." It was modernization at a movement of emergency: Chiang Kai-shek, with his limited program of, could not by itself withstand Japan in

[37] Taylor, "Reconstruction," 311.

[38] Taylor, *Memoir, 127.*

[39] Taylor, "Reconstruction," *139.*

a full-scale war. The situation in China was no longer the little problem of a band of Communists fleeing Kiangsi, but a problem for Asia.[40]

The Far East was in crisis—and the West should not merely serve as a model of inspiration but as an actor of intervention. Modernization was no longer a political-economic discourse stemming from nineteenth-century China-West contact, as in 1932, but an immediate program of organization aided by Westerners by 1938. But how, and by whom, should intervention occur? If the Asia-Pacific formed one chessboard of American geopolitics—"the Pacific was becoming the political, economic and racial centre of gravity of the World," Taylor wrote—then the role of scholars was to compare and contrast across national boundaries "to understand and interpret at least one of the countries involved," as Taylor aspired.[41]

The mist of China in the Far East for the Marxian-inspired scholar, the young Englishman George Edward Taylor, had faded. *Citizen* Taylor—as he stressed in his "Biographic Statement" to Lieutenant Colonel Joseph T. Little of the Office of Strategic Services—now concerned himself only with the position of the United States in a Pacific it was actively making.[42]

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[40] George Edward Taylor to Francis and Ivy White, December 5, 1936 in *Memoir*, chap. "Letter from London," 138.

[41] Taylor, "Fellowship Application," Box 3, *Taylor Papers*.

[42] "Biographic Statement…to Lieutenant Little," Box 1, *Taylor Papers*.

America in the New Pacific: The OWI and World War II

"I shall become [an] American," Taylor joked then, in August 1939, protesting Neville Chamberlain over the Munich Pact, as he boarded the SS President Coolidge for Seattle, where he would head the Far Eastern Department at the University of Washington. By May 11, 1943, in Richmond, Virginia, the remark had become reality as he rose through the ranks of the Office of War Information.[43] In the fall of 1944, Taylor replaced Owen Lattimore, who had been embroiled in alleged Communist sympathy, becoming the Deputy Director overseeing the Far East.[44] Now, Taylor operated in a world solely cornered by American interests.

American expansion, as Taylor wrote in his 1942 Rockefeller Foundation-sponsored book *America in the New Pacific*, "is progressive because it assumes that the more the people of the East are westernized under free political institutions, the greater will be the prosperity and safety of the American republic."[45] The Westernization and modernization of the East demanded "a kind of vast W. P. A program," by America's initiation: like many of his contemporaries, Taylor believed that the experience of FDR's New Deal could be projected onto the global stage. With the menace of communism temporarily subdued, America now waged a struggle for free capitalism against monopolistic capitalism, while the agency of diverse Asian peoples, liberated by Americans, played a major role in the making of a new world.[46] What was equally important

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[43] Taylor to Reg and Svea Taylor, August 15, 1939; Taylor, *Memoir*, chap. "Letters En Route to Seattle," 209.

[44] Robert P. Newman, *Owen Lattimore and the Loss of China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1992), 128-130.

[45] George E. Taylor, "America in Asia," in *America in the New Pacific* (New York: The Macmillan Company, 1942), 17.

[46] George E. Taylor, "Asia for Whom?," in *America in the New Pacific*, 152.

was the battle for public opinion at home. Taylor urged Americans to become better informed about the nation's position and interests in the Pacific islands and in Asia. However, the attack on Pearl Harbor temporarily silenced the concerns of an isolationist body politic.[47]

To fight and win on both the home front and abroad, Taylor conducted studies of Japanese and incarcerated Japanese Americans and, through his position at the Office of War Information, advanced top-down strategies for shaping the political values of populations under expanding American power via understanding their social orientations.

"Who are the Japanese?" In 1942, Taylor framed the wartime problem in these terms. His exposure to questions of this kind began with "Who are the English?" in 1931. For the first time outside the British cultural sphere, Taylor, a young and voracious reader immersed in a plethora of interwar literature, encountered Dutch scholar G. J. Renier's *The English: Are They Human?* and Spanish historian Salvador de Madariaga's *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards: An Essay in Comparative Psychology*, published three years earlier, in 1928.

Renier's *The English*, a polemic, staged a carnival of ideas, ranging from the making of English national identity as an elite project emerging from the industrialist class's defeat of the landed gentry to the assumption that Englishmen "have a greater interest in sex" yet were ashamed of bodily revelation to any degree, believing that "their bodies are wicked and must not be observed."[48] De Madariaga, a pacifist teaching at the Geneva School of International Studies, first developed the ideas that became *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards* through a series of

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[47] America's Pacific Policy: The Role and the Record, Pacific Affairs, Vol. 14, No. 4 (Dec., 1941), pp. 430-447, 444.

[48] C. E. M. Jonas, "The English, Are They Human?," *The Spectator*, July 18, 1931, 17; George E. Taylor, "Adventure in Ideas, or, Coming to My Sense," 3, *Taylor Papers*.

lectures while also working on disarmament efforts for the League of Nations. In psychological categories like "action," "thought," and "passion," and historical examinations of "love," "patriotism," "religion," under a given structure of government and communities, he thought he could better understand the national characters of European powers to facilitate "a state of happy co-operation and mutual trust."[49]

Observing China's social and political upheaval from the centers of political and economic power, Nanking and Peiping, Taylor let the ideas of Renier and de Madariaga cross-pollinate with theories of Chinese social development originally stemming from Karl August Wittfogel, a German expatriate in Peiping and a disaffected Communist. "Renier's book…[t]hinking mainly of the ruling class he decided [the English identity], unlike the lower classes, they were not," Taylor recalled, drawing from *The English* an initial impression of the Chinese system of prestige, which he understood as "not based on wealth but based on power."[50]

In the case of British industrialists or the KMT cadres, what mattered most to a nation's character was not only the will of the ruling elite, but also the kinds of societies the elites built their projects upon. The seeds of the same idea took root in different soils and flowered into different projects. Taylor's friendship with exile historian Wittfogel further solidified this impression: Wittfogel, expelled from the Soviet Communist movement, hold a view that contradicted Marx's theory of development: instead of the four stages of "primitive, feudal, bourgeois, socialist," in progression, Wittfogel argued, in words of Taylor, "Oriental societies [were] different in kind, not in degree."[51]

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[49] Salvador de Madariaga, *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards: An Essay in Comparative Psychology*, with a prefatory note by Alfred Zimmern (London: Oxford University Press, H. Milford, 1928), A3.

[50] Taylor, "Adventure in Ideas," 9.

[51] Taylor, "Adventure in Ideas," 9.

In his 1940 essay *"Aspects in the Reconstruction of China,"* Taylor first established his analytical framework for examining contacts between China and the West since the nineteenth century, framing "Oriental self-governing societies" as bifurcating into either "spontaneously developing Western forms of organization" or "accepting some form of Western control or domination."[52] Taylor compares Asian nations' fates in relation to their relative speed in building modern states, categorizing premodern political orders into bureaucratic and warrior states. The former entailed traits such as wet farming, a civilian political ruling class, a centralized state, and a mixed money-and-barter economy; the latter featured dry farming, a military ruling class, and feudal landowners who bound the peasantry to the service of different landlords within a strictly barter-based economy.[53]

In Taylor's view, China, Egypt, and India belonged to the category of the bureaucratic state, which he treated as a determining factor in their slower adaptation to the West, while Japan and Europe, by contrast, belonged to the category of warrior states and thus developed more rapidly. Asia's troubles, Taylor argued, arose from the decline of the old imperial order and the rapid ascent of a semi-Westernizing new power. The Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, however, forced him to revise this formula: in a world of "self-regenerating civilizations of great distinction," America had to treat China as an ally while confronting Japan's ruling class and studying the Japanese people.[54]

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[52] George E. Taylor, "Aspects in the Reconstruction of China," *Proceedings of the Institute of World Affairs*, vols. 17–18 (1940): 16–21, 16.

[53] Taylor, "Aspects in the Reconstruction of China," 16-17.

[54] Roger Bland, "Dr Alexander Hamilton Leighton, MD, FRCPC, FRCPsych (Hon.)," *Psychiatric Bulletin* 32, no. 12 (December 2008): 477, https://doi.org/10.1192/pb.bp.108.023697.

"Can you tell me who the Japanese are?" Returning to Washington D.C. in the summer of 1942 from a two weeks visit to the Poston Japanese American detention camp in Arizona, Taylor posed this question to Alexander H. Leighton, a sociologist and psychiatrist in the U.S. Navy Medical Corps; Leighton, who had spent more time in Poston, replied, "No, but I can work it out."[55] The war mobilized the study of Japanese behavior, bringing together scholars from different disciplines to U.S. military organizations. Leighton was not wrong about the field's murky state: when the Office of War Information (OWI) convened its initial circle of psychological warfare experts, Taylor found them largely at a loss. Breaking the silence, Geoffrey Gorer, a close associate of Margaret Mead, proposed that Japanese male aggression originated in toilet training and that Japanese women's supposed obedience resulted from the lack of it.[56]

Taylor offered a more differentiated approach to the Japanese question. Having spent time at the Poston internment camp, he drew a clear distinction between the *Issei*, the first generation of Japanese immigrants barred from naturalization by U.S. citizenship law, and the *Nisei*, who were born on American soil and had undergone American education and socialization. He paid special attention to the *Kibei*—American-born Japanese who had received a Japanese education—whom he regarded as the group most open to suspicion and most capable of espionage or fifth-column activity.[57] Yet the purpose of placing, in Taylor's words, the

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[55] George E. Taylor, "The Value of Values," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*, 1; Taylor, *memoir*, vi.

[56] Taylor, "The Value of Values," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*, 2; "Jackson School Oral History Project," 21, *Taylor Papers*.

[57] George E. Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst," *The Atlantic*, April 1943, 101-102.

"evacuees" into different departments was to aid the construction of a cohesive democratic community at Poston, a goal for "ultimate assimilation."[58]

Taylor therefore proposed a framework of rules, boundaries, and expectations for cooperation, specifying who could assume leadership positions, who required Army supervision, and how authority within community governance and authority on deciding the distribution of labor and compensation should vary across groups.[59]Acknowledging the material hardships of confinement, Taylor nevertheless hoped that internment would become a positive experience, one in which Japanese Americans would "leave … in pride, feel free to grow, and … have faith in American institutions."[60] After Poston, Taylor returned to Washington, D.C., with the conviction that the camp was not merely a wartime exception but "an experiment and a test case" for America's future global responsibility of relocating displaced populations and administering public services to peoples "released from long-endured bondage."[61]

If Taylor believed that order on the home front could be secured through the proper management of the "Japanese in our midst," the war in the Pacific raised larger and more perilous questions for American policymakers: to temporarily cast aside the global project Taylor envisioned, Poston nevertheless provided Taylor and his team in the OWI's Foreign Morale Analysis Division (FMAD) with an important example of wartime research: by surveying and concentrating Japanese in America, FMAD gained the freedom to conduct psychological interviews with any Japanese subjects of their demand and enjoyed extensive access to a

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[58] Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst," 106.

[59] Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst," 107-108.

[60] Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst," 109.

[61] Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst," 110.

collection of five thousand translated personal diaries written during the war.[62] Within FMAD, Taylor and Alexander Leighton—whom Taylor had first encountered at Poston and later joined again in Washington, D.C.—assembled an interdisciplinary team that included, notably, Clyde and Florence Kluckhohn, Ruth Benedict and Morris Opler.[63] Taylor defined the group's research agenda by arguing that the fusion of psychology, sociology, and anthropology into a greater social science could produce not only nuanced descriptive analysis but also predictive insight for policymaking.[64]

From 1942 onward, Taylor and FMAD continued to generate research and policy recommendations while the United States quickly gained a decisive advantage over Japan in the Pacific War. In January 1943, President Franklin D. Roosevelt joined the Allied leaders in issuing the Casablanca Declaration, which proclaimed the demand for the "unconditional surrender" of the Axis powers, including Imperial Japan under Hirohito.[65] One conclusion FMAD made that had caught the attention of Elmer Davis, the director of OWI was its contrarian stand that the United States should not explicitly attack, humiliate and gesture the removal of Emperor Hirohito after the war.

Taylor advanced a threefold argument. First, FMAD rejected the racially charged deterministic view that the Japanese were a swarm of people who would "never surrender" and that negotiation was therefore futile. Second, the team examined the dynamics of elite Japanese politics, arguing that the irreconcilability between the Army and Navy left the Emperor as the

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[62] Taylor, "The Lesson from a Wartime Study," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*, 2.

[63] Taylor, "A few comments on what I consider…," Box 8, Folder 1-36, 1-2, *Taylor Papers*.

[64] Tayler, "The Lesson from a Wartime Study," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*, 2.

[65] "The Casablanca Conference, 1943," in "Milestones in the History of U.S. Foreign Relations, 1937–1945," Office of the Historian, U.S. Department of State, accessed March 17, 2026.

sole source of unifying authority and therefore "the only institution that could bring about an organized surrender." Third, Taylor argued that within the Japanese "basic value system," the principle of imperial lineality ranked above all other values and served as the social backbone of Japan, outweighing modern institutions such as civilian government and the military.[66] Between April and August 1945, the Truman administration, still adjusting to the transition following Roosevelt's death, adopted FMAD's proposal. Ellis M. Zacharias, an U.S. Navy rear admiral who served as attaché in Tokyo and spoke fluent Japanese, delivered sixteen psychological warfare radio broadcasts that advanced a modified surrender message, omitting explicit reference to Hirohito and suggesting that Japan would not face a prolonged occupation.[67]

After the war, Taylor and his colleagues were widely recognized for what they regarded as FMAD's wartime innovations. In retrospect , Taylor believed that FMAD's recommendations had played a role in saving millions of lives by helping the United States avoid a prolonged and destructive ground war, with all the costs that amphibious invasion and land occupation would have entailed. To him, the postwar U.S.-Japan settlement under a sanitized constitutional monarchy appeared to vindicate the central premises of FMAD's wartime analysis. In the years after World War II, Taylor's collaborators attained great professional success. Ruth Benedict's 1946 *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword*, shaped by her wartime research, helped cement the notion of Japan as a "shame culture" in American public consciousness and established her prominence in anthropology. Clyde and Florence Kluckhohn resumed their academic posts at

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[66] Taylor, "A few comments on what I consider…," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*, 1; Taylor, "The Value of Values," Box 8, Folder 1-36, *Taylor Papers*.

[67] Taylor, "Adventure in Ideas, or, Coming to My Sense," 10, *Taylor Papers*.

Harvard and went on to pioneer Value Orientation Theory in the Department of Social Relations.[68]

Taylor found meaning in advancing the study of the "non-Western world." In a devastated Eurasian landscape, where the United States had emerged as a dominant power across vast landmasses and oceans despite its limited experience with the languages, cultures, and histories of those regions. Taylor embraced a positivist lesson he drew from Poston: reconstruction depended upon balance. At Poston, this meant navigating between "building up a permanent labor camp" and permitting "a too rapid dispersal of the evacuees at this stage [mid-1942]." In the Asia-Pacific, it meant avoiding a prolonged military occupation that would reproduce the logic of the old empire while leaving a war-torn region vulnerable to anarchy and ongoing immiseration.[69]

However, while Taylor taught at the National War College as a visiting professor and consulted another fellow faculty member, the director of the newly created Office of Policy Planning, George F. Kennan on grand strategy in Asia, his former supervisor Alexander Leighton, having returned to the practice of psychiatry, came to think differently about American intervention in the world.[70] Leighton, who had spent fifteen months conducting longitudinal research in Poston, published his account of the internment in *The Governing of Men: General Principles and Recommendations Based on Experience at a Japanese Relocation Camp*. In his clinical review of the nature of cohesive social change, he argued that confining people against

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[68] Ruth Benedict, *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword: Patterns of Japanese Culture* (Boston: Mariner Books, 2006); "Kluckhohn, Clyde," in *Theory in Social and Cultural Anthropology: An Encyclopedia*, ed. R. Jon McGee and Richard L. Warms, vol. 2 (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications, 2013), 439–441.

[69] Taylor, "The Japanese in Our Midst, " 103.

[70] Taylor, "Adventure in Ideas," 18. Bland, "Dr Alexander Hamilton Leighton," 477.

their will and putting people of all types into a narrow space could never achieve its objective. In the end, Leighton remained inconclusive on the Poston experiment. Leighton drew the title of his book from an alleged remark by Georges Danton before his guillotine execution: he put it, "Oh, it were better to be a poor fisherman than to meddle with the governing of men."[71]

Taylor in the Cold War: Far Eastern Studies and the Psychological Strategy Board

Amid the opening decades of the Cold War, Taylor oversaw a series of departmental mergers and discipline-building while also participating in psychological and public communication efforts in Asia under intense political contestation. The "loss" of China in 1949, as the Chinese Communists emerged victorious over the Kuomintang, and the outbreak of the Korean War in 1951 fueled public panic and McCarthyism in the United States; they were seen as a series of Soviet Union orchestrated revolutions and wars that rapidly carried Communism across Asia. Yet the Second World War sealed the coffin of the old colonial empires. Across Asia and Africa, demands for national independence surged against the imperial practice of spheres of influence and rattled the transatlantic order now led by the United States.

Taylor, now a seasoned practitioner in the study of non-Western groups and an adviser on policy, faced a People's Republic of China closed off to the United States for primary sources and field research. He therefore turned to the study of Chinese and Southeast Asian behavior outside the communist sphere, using comparison to guide the United States through the perplexing relationship between the Communist bloc and national independence movements in Southeast Asia, which drew participants from both the nominal ideological left and right.

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[71]" U.S. at War," *Time* 45, no. 26 (June 25, 1945): 18.

In a 1953 memorandum to Dr. Raymond B. Allen, president of the University of Washington and director of Truman's Psychological Strategy Board, Taylor provided an analysis of the prevailing communist sympathetic sentiment in Southeast Asia at the height of the Korean War, as "the problem of intellectual communication." As he wrote, "The average person [in Southeast Asia] thinks of the West as a highly industrialized civilization, materialistic in culture and philosophy," yet Southeast Asians considered the West to lack a "humanistic tradition" and to be invested only in "the search for raw materials and markets."[72]

Such a blatant Marxist reading of the West indicated, as Taylor argued, not necessarily hostility toward the capitalist West, nor an orientation to follow the Soviet or Chinese line of World Communist Revolution, but rather an anxiety in the search for intellectual and institutional frameworks for development. The economic study of the West had led to a "divorce between religion, ethics, and economics," as Taylor wrote, and was "absent of general institutional pattern or theory of institutional development."[73] For Southeast Asians who aspired to build their newly independent nations from their unique cultural traditions, their largely feudal and comprador economies, and collective social ethos, the Adam Smithian homo-economicus seemed far-fetched from their reality. However, Marxist economics did provide a sense of the stage of development in line with their demands.

Taylor proposed that the questions Americans should encourage Southeast Asians to ask were, "How did the American people acquire so many of the good things of life? How does one go about getting the same thing at home?" Otherwise, Marxist pseudo-science would plague their minds. Intellectual communication from the United States was vital to the educated people of the

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[72] George Edward Taylor, Memorandum to Dr. Raymond B. Allen, "The Problem of Communism," September 13, 1952, *Taylor Papers*, 1.

[73] Taylor, "The Problem of Communism," *Taylor Papers*, 2.

newly emerged nations, and the priority of the State Department was to find people and appropriate literature to facilitate exchange. In one instance, Taylor recommended a book by Frederick Martin Stern, titled *Capitalism in America: A Classless Society*, as an effective refutation of Marxism.[74]

For ex-Communists, "reborn capitalists," as Taylor believed himself capable of persuading, he suggested establishing a "comparative study of communism" program through semi-private means, since circumventing the McCarran Internal Security Act would be difficult. If the program could not bring ex-Communists to the United States, it should consider locations like London and Paris. However, Taylor never fully set McCarthyism aside, as he also stressed: "While the knowledge and experience of ex-Communists should be fully exploited, they should not be in a controlling position."[75]

Yet in a long view, the ad hoc psychological warfare and public communication of the Second World War could not satisfy the demands of the United States in the Cold War. In a prolonged contestation, in which the threat of thermonuclear weapons barred direct conflict between the United States and the Soviet Union, competing projects of construction and destruction occurred simultaneously across five continents and within nearly every aspect of social life. To win the Cold War, Taylor turned to building academic institutions of lasting durability.

Taylor visioned a new kind of area study: through his stewardship of the University of Washington's Far Eastern and Russian Institute and the creation of the interdisciplinary field of Far Eastern scholarship, he helped give birth to a program that aimed to "bring together

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[74] Taylor, "The Problem of Communism," *Taylor Papers,* 3.

[75] Taylor, "The Problem of Communism," *Taylor Papers,* 5.

disciplinary specialists and area experts to research big questions that had vexed Far Eastern scholars for generations."[76] These questions ranged from political and civilizational theory to ancient economies and geography, to contemporary geopolitics and theories of social development.[77]

In Taylor's 1959 speech titled *"*The Importance of Asian Studies in American Higher Education*,"* delivered at Indiana University, he articulated a threefold argument. First, he accounted for the decline and the rejuvenation of Western studies of Asia. He identified the waning of the late 19th-century high-colonial indifference—summed up in "Why study civilizations which were about to disappear?"—as European empires collapsed by the end of the Second World War.[78] Second, in a new era, he stressed the importance of studying "one civilization among many" and proposed a new set of inquiries for scholarship. The "scientific challenge," as he phrased it, was "the need for basic research on the nature of Asian societies."[79] The new mode of knowledge production would be interdisciplinary, transnational in scope, and collaborative in labor, countering his long-held observation that "the lack of well-established analytical concepts [in Asian studies] raises the corresponding danger that individual research might be sterile and unprofitable because it is concerned with the small pieces of a picture whose total outlines are not yet clear."[80]

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[76] Matthew Linton, "Understanding the Mighty Empire: Chinese Area Studies and the Construction of Liberal Consensus, 1928–1979" (PhD diss., Brandeis University, 2018), 127.

[77] Linton, "Understanding the Mighty Empire," 132.

[78] George E. Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies in American Higher Education," speech delivered at Indiana University, November 11, 1959, Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 2.

[79] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 3.

[80] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 9.

The rise of Communism made such a methodological shift ever more imminent. Taylor argued for a comparative study of Communism in both the Soviet Union and China and rejected the notion that the origins of the Cold War were merely a geopolitical consequence of the Second World War; he traced the cultural and political origins of the communist mode of governance in civilizational language and considered it as a form of non-Western values and traditions.[81] Cold War Asia scholars, Taylor argued, needed to study Communist China alongside "the society that the Communists are struggling to change."[82]

To respond to the concern of setting winning the Cold War, an explicit political goal, for scholarly knowledge pursuit, Taylor wrote, "[t]he contours of academic life ultimately conform in very large measure with the realities of power."[83] Subsequently, he praised Senator Henry Jackson's support for the National Defense Education Act of 1957 and described the administrative mechanisms through which research institutes were reshaped into a new form of federal-private partnership for knowledge production.[84]

In 1928, Salvador de Madariaga wrote in the introductory note for *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards*, "[f]or the Geneva School of International Studies was founded in the belief, growing out of the study of ancient Greece, that what is most needed for the understanding and practical handling of international affairs is neither the development of special disciplines, nor the imparting of information on current events, but a method of approach

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[81] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 7-8.

[82] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 8.

[83] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 6.

[84] Taylor, "The Importance of Asian Studies," Box 6, Folder 19, *Taylor Papers,* 6.

combining the knowledge and high standard of the specialist with a constant sense of the variety and complexity of the modern world."[85] De Madariaga, both a scholar who pioneered an interdisciplinary study blending history and psychology and a policy practitioner for international disarmament, placed high hopes in the League of Nations.

He saw it as the institutional embodiment of the combined approach he proposed for international studies. In postwar Geneva, the city where he lived, he found the promise of "a human laboratory for the study of contemporary world affairs." In this laboratory, university was a place that could make these resources available to serious students, many of them supported by international scholarships. There, he believed, the liberal international spirit of the League of Nations could mend national hostility and trauma from the First World War.[86] However, history turned otherwise. The Japanese invasion of Manchuria and the Italian invasion of Ethiopia revealed the League of Nations to be a brittle liberal fantasy, and the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War, followed by the rise of Francisco Franco, drove de Madariaga into permanent exile in England. He did not return to Spain until two years before his death in 1976.[87]

Taylor, an early and voracious reader of de Madariaga, lived his formative years in the shadow of de Madariaga's shattered dream. The rise of the United States and its Cold War project seemed to give that dream a second life in the hands of intellectuals who took the touch from de Madariaga. This time, however, the utopian vision of liberal humanism served as the rationale for a violent struggle against communism. The collaborative ethos once imagined in the League of Nations was reconfigured within an insular national security state and an expanding

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[85] De Madariaga, *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards,* A1.

[86] De Madariaga, *Englishmen, Frenchmen, Spaniards,* A1.

[87] "Salvador de Madariaga, Writer, Ex-Diplomat, Dies," Washington Post, December 14, 1978, accessed March 17, 2026, https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/local/1978/12/15/salvador-de-madariaga-writer-ex-diplomat-dies/bc1012f7-4f10-4278-ad9a-52fb7761c81b/.

American hegemony. Scholarship funding was now packaged in the name of national defense, while university towns as laboratories of knowledge flourished reciprocally with the militarism that turned vast swaths of the world into laboratories of violence.

Cold War as an Aftermath: the Making of George E. Taylor

Rather than an emergency response to a sudden revelation of Soviet threat, the Cold War emerged from a longer trajectory of American expansion in which anti-communism operated as counter-insurgency through American proxies, Americans aided the emerging states of the Global South with alternative capitalist development methods, and incubated the academic disciplines for area studies. In the story of George E. Taylor's pre–Cold War trajectory, these elements reaffirm that the Cold War belonged to a longer process in the rise of the United States that carried forward the legacy of the West's influence over the Rest.

This process unfolded over a long century of expanding American power: from the Spanish–American War that brought the United States to the Pacific and to the Philippines, to the Immigration Act of 1924 (the Johnson–Reed Act) that created special quotas for Europeans, especially Anglo-British migrants who enjoyed privileged imperial mobility in the Far East, as Taylor himself did, to the interwar 1930s, when the apparent vacuum of American state power coexisted with a global missionary project of modernizing the "backward" world, and with the building of Progressive institutions that enabled (pseudo-)scientific methods for understanding, categorizing, and governing the non-Western world.

Taylor's formative years also embodied many aspects of the making of a Cold War intellectual: he was educated within a prism of interwar scholarship ranging from Marxian

materialism to behavioral psychology and social science, politicized in an increasingly destabilized world, and drawn toward refuge and opportunity in American academia. Yet his story may invite less sympathy than those of many of his contemporaries: his seamless integration into American society as an Englishman, his young expatriate life in China's foreign concession lands, and his initial association with political power in the far less defensible Chiang Kai-shek's KMT distinguished him from the transatlantic German Jewish émigrés.

These émigrés saw the disintegration of Weimar liberal democracy in the face of Nazism and Soviet Communism, escaped the horrors of the Holocaust, and overcame the isolation of language and culture in joining FDR's America to fight for the survival of their civilization. Historians have therefore often made a sympathetic case for them, tracing the transatlantic origins of the Cold War to a worldview that understood the struggle against the Soviet Union as a continuation of the fight against totalitarianism.[88] Taylor revealed less an interwar contingent of becoming American than an Anglo-American imperial lineage of the frontiersman and the ever-expanding frontier.[89]

In this sense, the Cold War was less a sudden beginning than the final act of a drama whose dress rehearsals had lasted for decades; the same actors had bowed before familiar audiences, though the curtain had only begun to descend, soon to be called the iron curtain, where the longstanding violence hid beneath the balcony seats of the Long Peace.

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[88] For a reading sympathetic to Weimar émigrés yet critical of Cold War liberalism, see, for one example, Bessner, *Democracy in Exile*, 13.

[89] For the framing of twentieth-century American activities in Asia, especially China, as an extension of nineteenth-century continental frontier expansion, see William Appleman Williams, "The Frontier Thesis and American Foreign Policy," Pacific Historical Review 24, no. 4 (November 1955): 379–95.

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